

Why AI Makes You Feel Smarter Than You Are

Cognitive Offloading, Perceived Understanding, and Cognitive Drift

Cognitive Drift Papers —Concept Note #7

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The Basic Pattern

AI can dramatically improve the quality, speed, and clarity of what a person produces.

That improvement can feel like an improvement in understanding.

Sometimes it is.

Sometimes the system has done more of the cognitive work than the user realizes.

The core sequence is:

question → cognitive delegation → fluent response → perceived understanding → cognitive drift

What Is Cognitive Offloading?

Cognitive offloading is the use of an external tool to reduce the mental work required for remembering, reasoning, organizing, or deciding.

People have always offloaded cognition into writing, diagrams, calculators, search engines, and other people.

AI changes the scale of this process.

It does not merely store information.

It can generate explanations, structure arguments, compare options, infer relationships, and simulate reasoning.

The user receives the output of a cognitive process without necessarily performing every step of that process.

Why the Effect Feels Like Intelligence

AI responses often arrive in a form associated with understanding.

The language is fluent.

The structure is clear.

The distinctions appear organized.

The conclusion feels complete.

Because the response emerged from the user's question, the resulting clarity can feel internally owned.

The person may experience the answer as an extension of their own thinking, even when much of the reasoning was externally generated.

This creates a gap between **access to an explanation** and **possession of the underlying understanding**.

The Hidden Substitution

The substitution is subtle:

producing a good question becomes confused with producing a good answer

recognizing an explanation becomes confused with being able to reconstruct it

editing a response becomes confused with generating the reasoning behind it

using intelligence becomes confused with having performed the intelligence

None of these abilities are trivial.

But they are not identical.

A person can select, refine, and apply a strong answer while still being unable to reproduce the reasoning without assistance.

Perceived Understanding

Perceived understanding is the feeling that a concept has been mastered because its explanation feels clear.

AI intensifies this effect because it removes friction.

The response can be simplified instantly.

Examples can be generated.

Objections can be answered.

Complexity can be reorganized until the subject feels obvious.

But ease of comprehension is not proof of durable understanding.

A person may understand the explanation while reading it and lose the structure once the system is removed.

When Offloading Becomes Cognitive Drift

Cognitive offloading is not inherently harmful.

It can expand what a person is able to think about and produce.

The drift begins when the external system's capabilities are misidentified as internal cognitive gains.

The person becomes more capable while using the system.

They may not become equally capable without it.

If this distinction remains invisible, confidence can grow faster than independent understanding.

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, this is a form of Cognitive Drift.

The representation of understanding becomes more persuasive than the underlying cognitive capacity.

How to Recognize the Pattern

The clearest test is reconstruction.

Can the person explain the idea without reopening the response?

Can they apply the reasoning to a new case?

Can they identify where the argument might fail?

Can they rebuild the conclusion from first principles?

If not, the system may have produced access without ownership.

The answer was available.

The understanding was not fully integrated.

The Core Principle

AI can genuinely make people more capable.

But capability is now distributed across the person and the tool.

The mistake is not using the tool.

The mistake is confusing the performance of the combined system with the unaided ability of the individual.

AI makes you feel smarter when externally generated cognition is experienced as internally possessed understanding.

Cognitive Drift begins when access to intelligence becomes mistaken for ownership of intelligence.

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